

May 23th, 2009 – “Day hike” to Homer’s Nose Homer’s Nose (9023’) Southern Sierra

Well, as they go that was a rather epic trip for a day hike.

Right from the start this weekend was going to be a bit aggressive. Unlike last weekend where I had the benefit of working from home this week was spent out in Boise Monday through Friday evening. My plane landed at 6 pm on Friday (barring delays) and I was looking at a ~250 mile drive to the trailhead with no option to carpool due to how late I was leaving.

So at 8:00 pm I left my apartment and set out north along the 5 freeway. Fortunately traffic wasn’t bad and I was jazzed enough at the thought of climbing another mountain that I had a fairly easy drive. Sometime around 1 am I was driving down a dark dirt road in the middle of nowhere watching skunks hiss at me from the bushes when I came around a corner and found I was at a small campground called South Fork. I know the license plate of the leaders’ vehicle so without too much trouble I found the correct campsite.



I didn't bother with a tent. I just laid my sleeping pad in the bed of my pickup and I was out.

4:30 am came oh so very early and I had to roll out and get ready for a 5 am trail departure.



Besides the leaders, a husband and wife pair named Larry & Barbee Tidball, there were two other participants who had been staying in other sites. We all got ready, signed in, and by 5 am we were headed down (up?) the trail.

The first part of a mile or so was down a trail paralleling the river I'd fallen asleep last night listening to. Through this section we had to watch our steps due to the large number of salamanders underfoot.



As the sky lit up we were able to make out our first view of a peak off in the distance. Well, we thought it was the peak anyway due to its prominent nature and the vaguely nose like shape. Homer's Nose is actually the less prominent but higher peak you see to the left



We quickly became intimately acquainted with a large amount of foliage that seemed to have blocked the remains of the old trail. We had been warned of this from trip reports made over the past few years and as it turned out we would end up tromping through all sorts of brush and debris for the next 10+ hours.



One minute we'd be climbing over some Manzanita and the next crawling on our hands and knees under a particularly dense section. Well, that's one way to get in touch with nature.



We did get some nice breaks from the brush where we passed through some rather steep meadows. Not too bad climbing up but we'd become much less fond of them when descending about 10 hours later.



Why yes, this is on the trail.



As we climbed higher we reached true forest terrain. We periodically found traces of the old trail that might take us 200-300 ft and then all of a sudden end in a wall of brush or just disappear leaving us to pick our way around along the general direction of our route. This isn't a problem, you can save a lot of time by shortcutting cross country sometimes, but the constant detouring around impassable walls of brush really slowed us down.



We reached a stream crossing and came across something rather striking, legions of lady bugs. They were just carpeting some of the branches and plants.



If we looked closer at a lot of the leafy plants we could see thousands of them.



Later when we came back by Joel decided to play with them. When we left that spot we had ladybugs crawling all over us for the next few miles.

After even more brush we made it up on a ridge that would take us to the peak.



Here we had two options. We could take the south slope which had heavy and at many times impassible brush or we could do the north side which was clearer but often became very steep and rocky.



Nevertheless after 9 hours of hiking we made the peak. As we climbed up the last section it started sprinkling on us though it never got hard enough for me to bother with my rain jacket.

The large rock in the background is the other peak next to Homer's Nose that was so prominent in the distance. I'm convinced that was the landmark that originally earned the name.



Coming back the brush wasn't any kinder to us. In fact due to minor route changes and just the long amount of time we'd been out it seemed worse in places.



At first the meadows were a welcome break from the brush but as we descended slightly to the west of the route we took up it became so steep that several members of our group stated they were the worst section of it all.



The fact we had to side hill meant we had to watch our ankles so as not to roll them and we did have one injury despite our care.

Of course when we were able to descend directly we came up with a new technique that I'm sure you will see in the next version of Freedom of the Hills, the grass ass glissade.



We did get to enjoy a nice sunset causing the ridge in front of us to glow pink.



As the sun went down it became obvious we wouldn't be back to camp before dark.



Fortunately I live for the chances to hike via headlamp after dark. We were all tired and there were some frustrations as we picked our way down a stream channel and had to reroute around various dry waterfalls we couldn't down climb but overall we kept our spirits and pushed on.



We made it back to camp at 9:30 pm after having left at 5:00 am that morning. Now there's a day hike for you.

We had all gotten rather intimate with a large amount of poison oak and as a result the others were itching (haha!) to get someplace with a shower to wash off. Despite that the leaders still took time to cook us dinner which consisted of a salad with olives, sausage cooked on a grill, and cobbler made from home grown apricots with a cream and cinnamon mix. And there was beer.

I really need to hike with Larry & Barbee more often...

So after dinner the others packed up and drove off. I stayed, not feeling a hotel was worth the cost considering I've never had a poison oak outbreak. So I sat by the fire pit for a time before pulling out my sleeping pad and quilt and falling asleep.

It's hard to bear falling asleep beside the fire with a roaring river in the background!

I woke up early the Sunday morning, packed up, and started the long drive home.

And, a postscript...

To top off the weekend I had to fly back to Boise first thing Monday morning. 4 am came very early as I was up late trying to get things sorted out at my apartment to prepare for the following weekends expedition.

I was apparently a little more tired than I thought because once I was on the plane to Phoenix I fell asleep. I usually doze off but this was rather deep including dreams of the plane having near collisions with other planes (during which I was upset I missed the opportunity to take pictures) and making aborted takeoffs. For some reason I remember being very cheerful at the prospect of the plane crashing. No, I haven't been traveling too much, why do you ask? ☺

I actually woke up in an empty plane with a flight attendant shaking me. Apparently I'd slept through the landing, everyone deplaning, and most of the crew cleanup cycle. She fortunately wanted to verify I was continuing on to Tampa and woke me up.

Oops. More sleep next time.

Coming next week, why only idiots ignore weather warnings and head up into the Sierra's anyway...